

Fly where the air is thin.

Meridian gets **one rotation**. That rules out maximising market size — the biggest markets are big *because* incumbents with slots, feed and scale already hold them. So we scored routes on **capturability**, not size:

Opportunity is demand that already exists, on planes that are already full, on a route nobody owns.

D

Demand

Is the market real?

Q4 passengers, 2015-19

G

Growth

Is it getting bigger?

vs 2010-14

S

Strain

Are the planes full?

passengers ÷ departures

R

Room

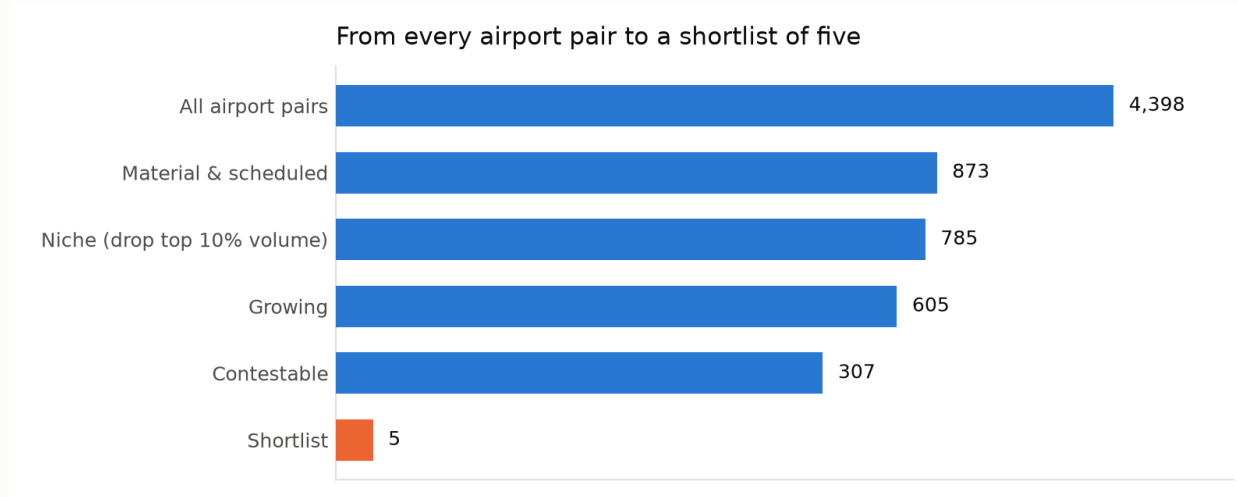
Can we get in?

1 – HHI of carrier shares

Each dial is a percentile rank inside the candidate pool, so they are unit-free and additive. **Room uses 1 – HHI, not carrier count** — two carriers can be an open duopoly or a 97% fortress, and only concentration tells them apart.

THE FUNNEL

4,398 airport pairs → 5 finalists



- **Material & scheduled** — $\geq 50k$ Q4 passengers, present all five years, $\geq 80\%$ scheduled. A rotation needs a repeating market, not charters.
- **Niche** — drop the top decile by volume. This is the client's instruction, applied as a rule rather than argued from evidence.
- **Growing** — demand rising against 2010-14.
- **Contestable** — ≥ 2 carriers and $HHI \leq 0.90$, which is what removes hub fortresses like ATL-AMS and DTW-AMS that look thin but are locked.

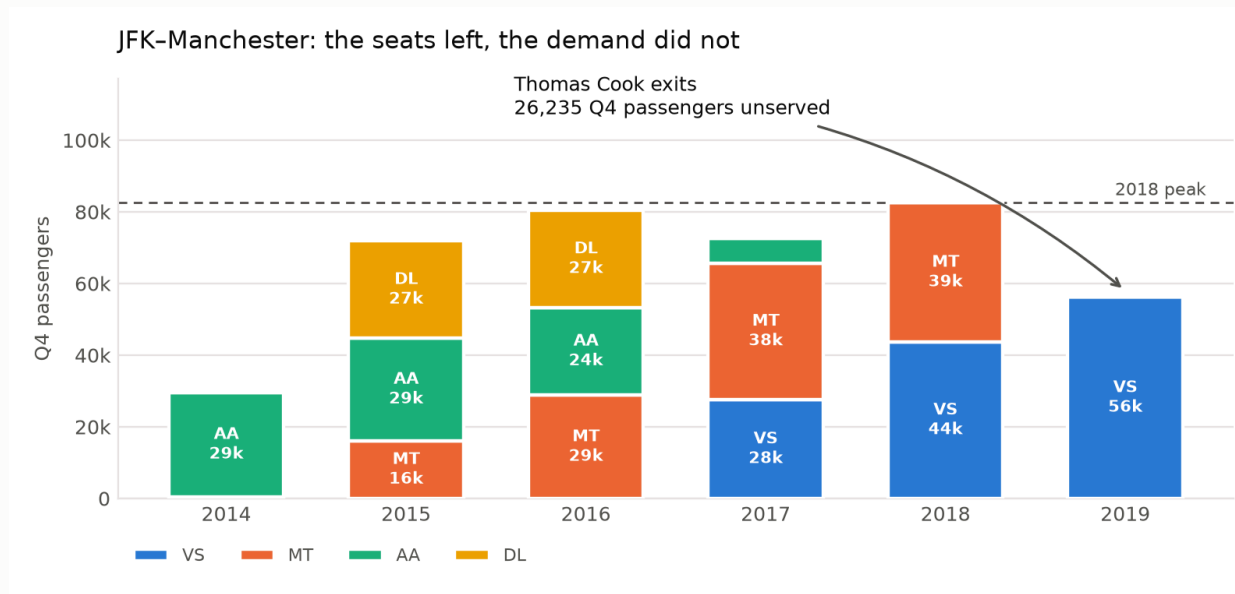
The index shortlists — it does not decide.

TAI ranks **LAX-HND first**. We reject it: Tokyo Haneda's US slots are allocated government-to-government and held by Delta, United, American and ANA. "Room" measures *concentration* — it cannot see that the seats are legally unobtainable. Three majors splitting a route evenly reads as contestable and is in fact a closed shop.

THE RECOMMENDATION

JFK ⇌ Manchester — and the reason is dated

Manchester is the UK's second gateway: the same national market as Heathrow, without the slot war Meridian cannot win. It is also the only finalist with a **catalyst**.



Thomas Cook collapsed in September 2019.

It carried **47% of the route** in 2018. Virgin Atlantic backfilled only part of it — and the planes still flew **320 passengers per departure**, so the demand did not evaporate. It went unserved.

26,235

Q4 passengers of
proven demand,
unserved

0.83

departures per day
needed to carry them

26,235 ÷ 344 passengers per departure = 76 flights over 92 days. The vacated demand is almost exactly **one daily rotation** — precisely the capacity Meridian has been funded for. We are not making a market or starting a price war; we are occupying a seat someone else left.

SENSITIVITY — WHERE WE COULD BE WRONG

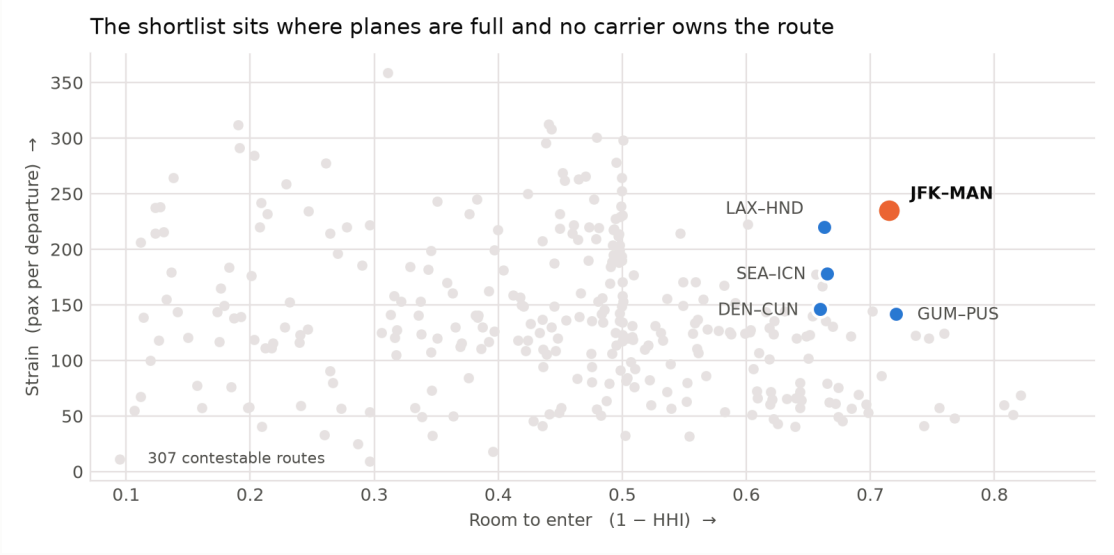
The weighting *is* the argument

WEIGHTING	TOP ROUTE	JFK-MAN
Equal (our prior)	LAX-HND	#2
Capturability-led	JFK-MAN	#1
Strain-led	JFK-MAN	#1
Room-led	JFK-MAN	#1
Growth-led	LAX-HND	#2
Size-led	LAX-HND	#24

JFK-MAN wins outright whenever **Strain** or **Room** carries real weight — that is, whenever the score reflects Meridian's actual weaknesses. Weight **size** instead and it falls to 24th. We are not hiding that; it is the whole sensitivity.

Try to break it yourself

Drag the four dials and watch the ranking re-order live:
[dashboard/index.html](#)



The single finding that would change our mind

Post-2019 schedule data showing **Manchester capacity restored to 2018 levels**. The case rests on one specific, dated vacancy — and our data stops three months after it opened. If it has been filled, the thesis is dead.

SWOT — and what this analysis cannot see

STRENGTHS

- Two profitable years — capital in hand
- No legacy network to defend; free to pick optimally
- One rotation = small, reversible commitment

WEAKNESSES

- No connecting feed — pure point-to-point
- No slot portfolio at constrained airports
- No alliance, JV or corporate contracts
- Unknown brand in every foreign market

OPPORTUNITIES

- Carrier failures vacate *proven* demand
- Secondary gateways are unslotted, under-served
- Monopoly routes carry fat, attackable fares

THREATS

- Virgin adds frequency and squeezes us
- The gap may already be backfilled
- Leisure skew → thin premium cabin, weak yield
- One route = zero diversification

LIMITATIONS OF THE DATA & METHOD

- **The files are Q4-only, and the window moves.** Passengers cover Sep-Dec then Aug-Dec; departures Oct-Dec then Sep-Dec. We forced a constant Oct-Dec window to kill the step artifacts — at the cost of the entire summer peak. Manchester is leisure-leaning, so its true annual demand is likely *understated* here.
- **The index cannot see non-concentration barriers** — slots, bilateral rights, gates, immunised JVs. This is why the top-scoring route is rejected by hand.
- **Five-year HHI hides the present.** JFK-MAN scores Room 0.70 across 2015-19, but in 2019 Virgin is the *only* carrier. We are entering a monopoly today.
- **Airport pair ≠ O&D market**, so the addressable market is smaller than the counts imply.
- **Corporate parents are invisible** — DY and DI on LAX-LGW are both Norwegian, scored as two competitors.

Assumptions: Q4 ordering approximates annual ordering; passengers ÷ departures is a usable load proxy absent seat counts; vacated demand persists rather than permanently re-routing via LHR/DUB/AMS; and history guides the launch year.